Red

By John Logan

Rothko stands, staring forward. Ken, a man in his early twenties, enters nervously. He wears a suit and tie. This is the first time he has been in the studio. Rothko gestures for him not to speak. Then he beckons for Ken to join him. Ken goes to Rothko, stands next to him. Rothko indicates the central painting (ie the audience)

ROTHKO: What do you see? *(Ken is about to respond—)* Wait. Stand closer. You've got to get close. Let it pulsate. Let it wrap its arms around you; let it ***embrace*** you. — Meet it halfway for God's sake! Lean forward, lean into it. Engage with it! . . . Now, what do you see? — Be exact — but sensitive. You understand? Be kind. Be a human being. These pictures deserve compassion, and they live or die in the eye of the sensitive viewer, they quicken only if the empathetic viewer will let them. That is what they deserve . . . Now . . . What do you see? *(Beat.)*

KEN: Red.

INTRODUCTION

Red is the color you feel when anger strikes your bones, and shudders through your being. Red is the color of the last rays of the sun touching you and filling you with warmth. Red is fire, red is lust. Red is passion, red is trust. Red reminds us that we are all simply phoenixes destined to burn.

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ROTHKO: Hang up your jacket outside. I appreciate you put on your Sunday clothes to impress me, it's poignant really, touches me, but it's ridiculous. We work hard here. Go hang up your jacket outside. *(Ken exits and returns without his jacket. Takes off his tie and rolls up his sleeves.)* We start every morning at nine and work until five. You'll help me stretch the canvases and mix the paints and clean the brushes and build the stretchers and move the

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paintings. You'll pick up food and cigarettes and anything else I want, any whim, no matter how demanding or demeaning. If you don't like that, leave right now. Answer me. Yes or no.

KEN: Yes.

ROTHKO: I am not your rabbi, I am not your father, I am not your shrink, I am not your friend, I am not your teacher —I am your employer. You understand?

KEN: Yes.

ROTHKO: I'm painting a series of murals now — *(He gestures all around.)* You'll help me put on the undercoat and then I'll paint them and then I'll look at them and then paint some more. *(Rothko moves away. Beat.)* How do ***they*** make you feel?

KEN: Give me a second. *(Ken moves to the middle of the room and takes in all the paintings.)* Disquieted.

ROTHKO: And?

KEN: Thoughtful . . . Um . . . Sad.

ROTHKO: *Tragic*.

KEN: Yeah.

ROTHKO: They're for a restaurant. *(Rothko smiles. He enjoys this.)* So I'm minding my own business when Mister Philip Johnson calls me. He's designing the new Seagram Building on Park Avenue. In this building there is to be a restaurant called the Four Seasons, like the Vivaldi, and on the walls of this restaurant . . . *(He gestures expansively to his paintings. Beat. Proud.)* Thirty-five thousand dollars they are paying me. *(Ken is impressed. Thirty-five thousand dollars is a fortune.)*

KEN: *(Beat . . . trying to impress his new employer)* I went to the Modern last night, saw the Picasso show.

ROTHKO: That man — though now a charlatan, of course, signing menus for money like Dali, when he's not making ugly little pots, also for money — that man at his best understood the workings of time . . . Tragic, really, to grow superfluous in your own lifetime. We destroyed Cubism, de Kooning and me and Pollock and Barnett Newman and all the others. We stomped it to death.

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KEN: You take pride in that. "Stomping" Cubism to death.

ROTHKO: The child must banish the father. Respect him, but kill him.

KEN: And enjoy it?

ROTHKO: Picasso I thank for teaching me that movement is everything! Movement is life. The second we're born we squall, we writhe, we squirm; to live is to move. Without movement paintings are what?

KEN: Dead?

ROTHKO: Precisely *(He gestures to his paintings.)* . . . Look at the *tension* between the blocks of color: the dark and the light, the red and the black and the brown. The more you look at them the more they move . . . they breathe . . . They're not dead because they're not static.

KEN: *(Excited.)* They *need* the viewer. Representational pictures are unchanging; they don't require the active participation of the viewer. In the Louvre in the middle of the night the "Mona Lisa" is still smiling. But do these paintings still pulse when they're alone? *(Ken is lost in thought. Rothko watches him, pleased.)* That's why you keep the lights so low. . . To help the illusion. Like a magician. Like a play. To keep it mysterious, to let the pictures pulsate. Turn on bright lights and the stage effect is ruined — *(Ken goes to the light switches. He snaps on all the lights. Ugly fluorescent lights sizzle on. The room immediately loses its magic.)*

ROTHKO: What do you see?

KEN: My eyes are adjusting . . . Just . . . White.

ROTHKO: What does white make you think of?

KEN: Bones, skeletons . . . Charnel house . . . Anemia . . . *Cruelty*. *(Rothko is surprised by this response.)*

ROTHKO: How does white make you *feel*?

KEN: Frightened? . . . It's like the snow . . . outside the room where my parents died. It was winter. I remember the snow outside the window: white *(Turns his attention to the*

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paintings.) . . . And the pictures in this light . . . They're flat. Vulgar . . . This light hurts them. *(Rothko turns off the fluorescent lights. The normal light returns.)*

ROTHKO: You see how vulnerable they are? . . . People think I'm controlling . . . It's not controlling, it's *protecting*. A picture lives by companionship. It dies by the same token. It's a risky act to send it out into the world. *(He abruptly stops to stare at his painting. He tilts his head. Like he's listening.* Bring me the second bucket. *(Ken, excited, brings him a brush and a bucket of dark maroon paint. Rothko is unsure. He looks at the painting. The moment is passing. He is getting desperate. To* himself, *frustrated.)* Come on . . . come on . . . come on . . . What does it need?

KEN: Red.

ROTHKO: I wasn't talking to you! *(Beat. Tragically, the moment has passed for Rothko. He flings the paintbrush away. It splatters. He spins on Ken.)* DON'T YOU EVER DO THAT AGAIN! *(He rages, stomping restlessly around the room:)* By what right do you express an opinion on my work? Who are you? "RED"?! — I don't even know what that means! You mean scarlet? You mean crimson? You mean plum-mulberry-magenta-burgundy-salmon-carmine-carnelian-coral? What is "RED"?! *(Rothko stands, getting his breath, collecting himself. Beat.)*

KEN: I meant sunrise. I meant the red at sunrise . . . The feeling of it. Sunrise is red and red is sunrise. *(Ken begins cleaning up.)* Red is heartbeat. Red is passion. Red wine. Red roses. Red lipstick.

ROTHKO: Arterial blood.

KEN: That too. *(Rothko thinks about it.)*

ROTHKO: Rust on the bike on the lawn.

KEN: And apples . . . And tomatoes.

ROTHKO: Lava. Lobsters. Scorpions.

KEN: Stop sign. Sports car. A blush.

ROTHKO: Slash your wrists. Blood in the sink. *(Beat.)* So . . . red. (*Rothko gazes thoughtfully at his painting then turns away)* I can't look at it now. It's too depressing.

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KEN: How can all that red be depressing?

ROTHKO: I don't see the red anymore . . .

KEN: What?

ROTHKO: Black. *(Beat.)* There is only one thing I fear in life, my friend . . . One day the black will swallow the red. *(He puts on his glasses again and stares at his painting.) (Beat)* I was walking up to my house last week and this couple was passing. Lady looks in the window, says: "I wonder who owns all the Rothkos." . . . Just like that I'm a noun. A Rothko . . . An overmantel.

KEN: A what?

ROTHKO: *(as Rothko speaks, they finish priming the next canvas)* The overmantels. Those paintings doomed to become *decoration*. You know, over the fireplace in the penthouse. They say to you, "I need something to work with the sofa, you understand. Here's a paint chip from the Sherwin-Williams" . . . . It's an investment . . . It goes with the lamp . . . It's interior decoration . . . It's anything but what it is. *(Beat.) (The priming is finished on the canvas and Rothko steps back and studies it. Musing.)* So . . . so . . . so . . . it'll do . . . What do you think?

KEN: It's a . . . a good ground, a good base layer. Nice and even. *(Ken smiles, Then he stops abruptly. Surprisingly, tears come to his eyes. The emotion is unexpected.)*

ROTHKO: What is it?

KEN: It's strange . . . I'm remembering something . . . The, um, color . . . is . . . Dried blood . . . When the blood dried it got darker. On the carpet where my parents died. *(Ken tries to shake off the thought. He moves away. But then he stops again. He can't shake the emotion. The canvas draws him back.)* It's exactly the color.

ROTHKO: What happened to your parents?

KEN: They were murdered.

ROTHKO: What happened? *(Ken stares forward, lost in thought. Beat.)* What do you see? *(Ken shakes his head. Beat.)*

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KEN: *(Reliving it)* I woke up . . . and the first thing I saw was the snow outside my window. But . . . but . . . It was really quiet. . . . And it's *cold*. There's a window open somewhere . . . Then I see my sister, just standing in the hallway, staring into my parent's room. My sister . . . she's standing in a puddle of pee. Her eyes . . . I go to the door and look in and see the snow first. And then the blood. The bed's stained with it. And the wall. They're on the bed . . . Apparently it was a knife. *(Beat.)* Burglars, I found out. At least two of them . . . I don't want my sister to see anymore. My little sister [I was seven] . . . I turn around and push her out and shut the door. The door handle . . . With blood . . . Is red. *(Beat.)* That's all.

ROTHKO: What happened to you two?

KEN: State took us. Foster homes. People were nice, actually. They kept us together. But they shuffled us around a lot. We were *rootless*… Never belonged . . . Never had a *place*. *(Ken continues to clean up. Pause.)* Can I ask you something? . . . Are you really scared of black?

ROTHKO: No, I'm really scared of the absence of light.

KEN: Like going blind?

ROTHKO: Like going dead.

KEN: And you equate the color black with death. . . Because black is the lack of red, if you will. The bright colors are your passion, your will to survive — your "life force." But if *black* swallows those bright colors then you lose that excess and extravagance, and what do you have left?

ROTHKO: [T]rust me, as you get older those colors are harder to sustain. The palate fades and we race to catch it before it's gone.

KEN: In reality we both know black's a tool, just like ochre or magenta. It has no effect. Seeing it as malevolent weird.

ROTHKO: You think so? What about equating white with death; like snow?

KEN: That's different. That's just a personal reaction. I'm not building a whole artistic sensibility around it.

ROTHKO: Maybe you should.

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KEN: Come on, a painter gets older and the color black starts to infuse his work, therefore, the cliché goes, he's depressed, he's fearing death. He's losing touch, he's losing relevance, he's saying goodbye.

ROTHKO: That's a cliché except for when it's not.

KEN: But it's not *true*. . . Look at Van Gogh; his last pictures are all color. He paints the most ecstatic yellows and blues know to man — then shoots himself . . . Or Matisse, his last works were nothing but great shocks of primary colors . . . . he was dying, he knew he was dying, but he was still Matisse. When he got too ill to hold a paintbrush he used scissors, cutting up paper and making collages. He never gave up. On his deathbed he was still organizing the color patterns on the ceiling. He had to be who he was.

ROTHKO: *(Rothko looks at him.)* In the National gallery in London there's a picture by Rembrandt called *Belshazzar's Feast* . . . Belshazzar, King of Babylon blasphemes, so a divine hand appears and writes some Hebrew words on the wall as a warning . . . In the painting these words pulsate from the dark canvas like something miraculous. Rembrandt's wrote "Mene, Mene, Tekel, Upharsin." "You have been weighed in the balance and have been found wanting." *(Beat.)* That's what black is to me . . .

******Scene*******

Ken is alone, building a wooden canvas stretcher/frame. Then the sound of a slamming door from outside surprises him. Rothko rages in, flinging off his overcoat and hat.

ROTHKO: THEY'RE TRYING TO KILL ME! I swear to God they're trying to kill me!

KEN: So . . . how did you like the exhibit? *(Rothko is not amused. He lights a cigarette.)*

ROTHKO: *(Seriously.)* These young artists are out to murder me.

KEN: Andy Warhol? *(Rothko doesn't even answer.)* You sound like an old man.

ROTHKO: My point is . . . People like me . . . My contemporaries, my colleagues . . . We all had one thing in common . . . We understood the importance of seriousness. *(Beat.)* You know the problem with those painters? They are painting for this moment right now. And that's all. Completely temporal, completely disposable, like Kleenex, like —

KEN: Like Campbell's soup, like comic books —

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ROTHKO: You really think Andy Warhol will be hanging in museums in a hundred years?

KEN: He's hanging alongside Rothko now.

ROTHKO: Because those goddamn galleries will do anything for money — cater to any wicked taste. That's *business*, young man, not art! *(Ken approaches. Not backing down.)*

KEN: You ever get tired of telling people what art is?

ROTHKO: No, not ever. Until they listen.

KEN: You're just mad because the barbarians are at the gate. And, whattaya know, people seem to like the barbarians.

ROTHKO: Of course they *like* them. That's the goddamn point! You know what people *like*? Happy, bright colors. they want things to be *pretty*. *(Explodes.)* "Pretty." "Beautiful." "Nice." "*Fine*." How are you? Fine. How was your day? Fine. How are you feeling? Fine. Well, let me tell you, *everything is not fine! (He spins to his paintings.)* Conflicted. Nuanced. Troubled. Diseased. Doomed. I am not fine. Look at these pictures. *Look at them!* You see the dark rectangle, like a doorway, , yes but it's also a gaping mouth letting out a silent howl of something feral and foul and primal and REAL. Not nice. Not fine . . . I AM HERE TO MAKE YOU THINK! . . . I AM NOT HERE TO MAKE PRETTY PICTURES! *(A long beat. Rothko roams, disturbed, trying to recover his equilibrium. Ken hasn't moved.)*

KEN: So said the Cubist, the second before you stomped him to death. *(Rothko stops, looks at him.)* "Tragic, really, to grow superfluous in your own lifetime" . . . Right? "The child must banish the father. Respect him, but kill him." . . . Isn't that what you said? . . . You guys went after Cubists and Surrealists and, boy, did you love it. And now your time has come and you don't want to go. Well, exit stage left, Rothko. Because Pop Art has banished Abstract Expressionism . . . *(Beat.)* Don't worry; you can always sign menus for money.

ROTHKO: How dare you?

KEN: *(Beat.)* Do you know where I live? Uptown? Downtown? Brooklyn? [Do] you know if I'm married? Dating? Queer?

ROTHKO: No. Why should I —? You're an *employee*. This is about me. Everything here is about me. You don't like that; leave . . . your neediness bores me —

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KEN: *(Explodes)* Bores you?! *Bores you?!* — *(Ken roams angrily.)* You know, not everything has to be so goddamn IMPORTANT all the time! Not every painting has to rip your guts out and expose your soul! Not everyone wants art that actually HURTS! Sometimes you just want a still life or landscape or soup can or comic book! N*othing* is ever good enough for you! Not even the people who buy your pictures! Museums are nothing about mausoleums, galleries are run by pimps and swindlers, and art collectors are nothing but shallow social-climbers. *(He stops, slows, realizing.)* Who's good enough to even *see* your art? . . . Is it just possible *no one* is worthy to look at your paintings? . . . That's it, isn't it? . . . We have all been "weighed in the balance and have been found wanting." *(He approaches Rothko.)* You say you spend your life in search of real "human beings," people who can look at your pictures with compassion. But in your heart you no longer believe those people exist . . . So you lose faith . . . you lose hope . . . black swallows red. *(Beat. Ken is standing right before Rothko.)* My friend, I don't think you'd recognize a real human being if he were standing right in front of you.

ROTHKO: *(defeated)* You're fired. *(Beat. Ken stares at him. He can't believe it.)* Write down your address, I'll send you your final check.

KEN: You owe me an explanation.

ROTHKO: I don't owe you anything — *(Ken pursues. Rothko tries to avoid him. The conflict builds. Rothko spins on him, points to the outside with the realization dawning that his artistic time is past.)* *Because your life is out there!* *(Beat.)* Listen, kid, you need to find your contemporaries and make your own world, your own life . . . You need to . . . make them look. *(Ken is moved. Rothko continues with quiet emotion.)* When I was your age, art was a lonely thing: no galleries, no collecting, no critics, no money. We didn't have mentors. We didn't have parents. We were alone. But it was a great time, because we had nothing to lose and a vision to gain. *(Beat.)* Okay? . . . Make something new. *(Rothko steps away. Ken gathers his things and starts to go. He stops at the door. He turns back.)* What do you see? *(Ken looks at the paintings. But then he looks at Rothko. Beat.)*

KEN: Red. *(Beat. Ken exits. Rothko stands alone.)*

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